Chapter 2

Propaganda and the Coins

The first bronze coins of Rome, minted sporadically in the first half of the third century B.C., have no standardized types, or pictures found on both sides of the coin. The silver coins, however, soon settled into standardized types, with the adoption of a Janus type on the didrachms beginning in the last quarter of the third century. With the introduction of the denarius ca. 211, only three types are used: Roma,[1] the Dioscuri,[2] and, by ca. 195, a deity in a quadriga or biga (occasionally a triga). The moneyer, who belonged to a board of three annual magistrates responsible for producing the coins, varied the choice of deity found in the chariot, possibly showing familial or personal attachment to a particular god or goddess. Yet on the whole, these types leave little room for familial propaganda; instead, they are a more generalized form of propaganda, employing symbols of the city of Rome.

At first, the coins were completely anonymous. Letters or symbols sometimes appeared on the reverses, but we cannot relate them to a moneyer or even a specific family. Anonymous denarii occurred sporadically through the first decades of the first century (e.g., see fig. 25), but within twenty years of the first minting of denarii, moneyers began to identify their families by their cognomina, nomina, or even three initials, usually in abbreviated form in the inscription, commonly called "legends," that are found on the reverses.[3]

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[1] The goddess is called Roma here because it is the most common convention. I do not propose to enter into the argument of whether the goddess portrayed is Rhome, Bellona, or Roma; my argument would not be changed in any case.

[2] The Dioscuri have a special place in Roman history since they had appeared at the battles of Regillus (496) and Pydna (168) to help lead the Romans to victory. They were also special protectors of the equites and were assimilated with the *Penates publici*. For discussions on the Roma and Dioscuri types, see Zehnacker 1:338–40; Crawford, *RRC* p. 715; G. MacDonald, *Coin Types: Their Origin and Development* (Glasgow: J. MacLehose and Sons, 1905), 191; C. Peyre, "Castor et Pollux et les Pénates pendant la période républicaine," *MEFRA* 74.2 (1962): 440.

[3] For an extended discussion of the use of names, see A. Rossetti, "L'introduzione dei nomi gentilizi nella monetazione romana repubblicana," *RIN* 89 (1987): 29–42.

It did not take long for the moneyers to identify themselves as well by fuller legends, such as QLC, (206–210, *RRC* 125) or TAMP (of the Baebii Tamphili, 194–190, *RRC* 133). This practice remained a rarity, however, through the first half of the second century; anonymous coins were still prevalent.

Coin types begin to diversify in the second half of the second century (see table).[4] They are generally categorized as moving from religious to more secular themes. By the second half of the second century, the moneyer's praenomen, nomen, and cognomen could appear on the obverse and reverse of the coin (at first the cognomen appeared on the obverse, and the praenomen and nomen on the reverse; very few coins were now anonymous). By about 140, the appellation "son of" could be added. In the first century, all three names of the moneyer usually appeared on the obverse (see fig. 49); rare coins even name the office that the moneyer held (see fig. 31). The burgeoning importance of the legend can be traced in coins minted for Caesar, which list all of his offices (e.g., *RRC* 467), down to the late Republican types that are completely epigraphic (e.g., *RRC* 534).

Bronze coins were minted much more sporadically than coins in precious metals and the types are much slower to change. The standard type on the denomination called the *as*, after a somewhat varied beginning, is Janus/prow (*RRC* 225). The first moneyer to break with tradition is C. Marcius Censorinus, who placed jugate heads of Numa Pompilius and Ancus Marcius on the obverse and two arches or two ships on the reverse (fig. 51; for a discussion of the coins, see chapter 8). After the 80s, there were no *asses* minted in Rome; provincial mints began minting *asses* in the 50s and the types were quite variable, but the *asses* generally do not carry types with references to ancient Rome.

The numismatic situation after Actium is unclear, particularly in regard to the coins' types, and it is not yet fully understood.[5] Of the issues assigned to the mint in Rome, Augustus' portrait occupies most of the obverses, with half again as many given over to deities. Reverses retain the diversity

[4] Cf. C. Classen, "*Virtutes Romanorum* nach dem Zeugnis der Münzen republikanischer Zeit," *RM* 93 (1986): 257–79, for a slightly different approach.

[5] Mattingly and Sydenham located all of the precious-metal mints in Asia Minor from the time immediately after the battle of Actium until 19 B.C. See *RIC*² 1, 54; also *BMCRE* 1:xv–xvi; see earlier E. Sydenham, "The Coinages of Augustus," NC 80 (1920): 18, 21. The *asses* of Cn. Piso are attributed to the mint of Rome in 23 B.C.; the issue includes the controversial Numa *asses* discussed in chapter 8. Sutherland (*RIC*², 31–32) close the Rome mint around, 40, with issues minted in 19, 17–15, 13, 12, 9, and 6–4.

of scope noticed in the late Republic, with one quarter of the types featuring military themes.[6]

Although the types concerned with the history of early Rome compose only a small percentage of Roman coin types, they persist after their introduction ca. 140, lapsing only during the early Empire. The types are pictured again during the second century and even later, under Constantine.[7]

The problem of defining propaganda on coins—or indeed of deciding whether Roman coin types *are* propagandistic—has recently been argued with fervor. Returning to the definition of propaganda outlined above, we may say that, to be propagandistic, the coin type should be used by an organized group, for the education or the information of a selected audience, in order to make that audience take a particular course of action or conform to a certain attitude intended by the organized group. This propaganda can be overt or counter propaganda, depending upon how it is viewed by the audience; by definition it is either agitation or integration propaganda, always vertical, and normally irrational.

That the coin types were used by an organized group—young members of the aristocracy (at least for most of the Republic)—is self-evident. The purpose of the types is generally supposed to be informational or educational: they are to advertise the moneyer to the general populace before his embarkation on a more prominent political career, with the selected audience being the citizens of Rome. Thus, the particular course of action intended by the types is for the viewer to vote for the young man (or his political associates) when he presents himself as a candidate.[8] The weak areas in this argument are two: a) that we do not know if the "advertising" purpose we attribute to the coin types was an ancient purpose, though we can guess that this is the case by the number of moneyers who rise to higher offices, and b) the minting of anonymous coins, though we have seen that this tradition is overthrown very soon in favor of names on coins.

As far as the effect of coins on the audience, we are at an almost complete loss. The people of antiquity have left precious little information of any sort about the very coins they must have handled every day. Nonetheless,

[6] See G. Belloni, "Significati storico-politici delle figurazioni e delle scritte delle monete da Augusto a Traiano," *ANRW* 2.1, 1002–3, for a discussion of early Imperial coin types.

[7] There is no study of the subject yet; see the brief mention in H. Mattingly, *Roman Coins 3d*, ed. (Chicago: Quadrangle Books, 1962) 165, 204, 242.

[8] See A. Burnett, *Coinage in the Roman World* (London: Seaby, 1987), 22, who proposes that the variety in coin types can be attributed to the *lex Gabinia* of 139, which introduced the secret ballot. The position of moneyer is now filled by young aristocrats positioning themselves for higher office.

what little notice *is* paid in the literary sources to coin types suggests that there was, at the very least, a limited appreciation of the types as propaganda.[9] This allows us only to state categorically that educated people at least understood propaganda on coins.[10]

We can, I think, extend this awareness to the lower, less-educated classes as well. Some visual symbols such as the wolf and twins were quite familiar to Roman citizens, in this case from statues, that were erected by the mid-Republic (see chapter 4), and these would need no identifying legend to make the propaganda understandable. This example can be multiplied, especially in the generalized propaganda of coin types of the mid-Republic, which included depictions of Roma, the Dioscuri, Janus, or a prow. Yet legends beyond the identifying "Roma" become a normal part of the coin type by 200–175, when personal names are first used. Since these legends become a crucial means of identifying the moneyer, the extent of literacy among the users of coins affects the reception of the propaganda.[11]

We have seen that the literacy rate in the mid-Republic was estimated at ten percent or less.[12] Yet Harris argues that by the time that we get more complicated legends, in our period of ca. 200–175, "more than a handful of citizens were now able to read," and the moneyers expected their legends

[9] For example, the denarius of M. Brutus minted after Caesar's assassination showing the pileus and daggers, which is mentioned by Dio Cassius (47.25.3); see also Matt. 22:19–21, where Jesus expects his audience to know, in general terms, what was on the coin.

[10] M. Crawford, "Roman Imperial Coin Types and the Formation of Public Opinion," in *Studies in Numismatic Method Presented to P. Grierson,* ed. C. Brooke (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1983), 50, where a nonliterary interest in coin types is cited in the discovery of an *as* of Domitian with the type of Fortuna found in London under the mast of a ship (cf. Crawford's view of coin propaganda, 51–52, 57–58). N. Hannestad, "Rome—Ideology and Art," in *Power and Propaganda,* Copenhagen Studies in Assyriology, Mesopotamia (Copenhagen: Akademisk Forlag, 1979), 7:362, 365, 379 n. 13, dismisses any propaganda value beyond the educated class; Zanker (*Images,* 14) agrees that coins that do not portray an ancestor or building were aimed only at a "small circle of rival families."

[11] G. Belloni, "Monete romane e propaganda," in *I canali della propaganda nel mondo antico: Contributi dell'Istituto di storia antica,* ed. M. Sordi (Milan: Università Catt. del Sacro Cuore, 1976), 4:131–33; M. Grant, *Roman Anniversary Issues* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1950), xv and n. 3, 8; idem, *Roman Imperial Money* (New York: Thomas Nelson and Sons, 1954), 8–9; C. Sutherland, "The Intelligibility of Roman Imperial Coin Types," *JRS* 49 (1959): 50; idem, "The Purpose of Roman Imperial Coin Types," *RN* n. 6, 25 (1983): 77, 79–80; idem, "Compliment or Complement?" *NC* 146 (1986): 90–93; C. Ehrhardt, "Roman Coin Types and the Roman Public," *JNG* 34 (1984): 46–49, 51–53; L. Morawiecki, *Political Propaganda in the Coinage of the Late Roman Republic* (Warsaw: Polskie Towarzystwo Archeologiczne i Numizmatyczne, 1983), 16–17; H. Chantraine-Mannheim, "Münzbild und Familiengeschichte in der römischen Republik," *Gymnasium* 90 (1983): 534–38.

[12] W. Harris, *Ancient Literacy* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1989), 158–59.

to have some impact.[13] Perhaps more importantly, Harris argues that the vast majority of centurions and cavalry could read, if only to participate in the giving of the nightly password, as described in Polybius (6.34.8).[14] Indeed, we have already noted that tracts, by the late Republic, were a means of written propaganda circulating in the various armies. His conclusion, that "the creative use of coin legends from the late Republic onwards suggests that they were expected to carry an intelligible message to an audience of a certain size," emphasized that the masses were not literate, but the army had a large number of literate and semiliterate soldiers to read the legends for the illiterate.[15]

Although most modern work has centered on this problem concerning Imperial coins, the same objections may be raised for Republican coins. The objections are fourfold: the barrier of literacy, the silence of ancient authors on coin types, the varying types, and the objection that the educated, at least, would be immune to or disinterested in the propaganda displayed on coins.[16] We cannot fathom the silence of our sources, or the effect of the propaganda, nor can we study the effect of such advertisement on the educated class. And the variety of the types has been used as evidence that coin types both are and are not propagandistic.[17]

Part of the problem of identifying the existence of propaganda on coins may lie in the type of propaganda used. Few would disagree that the Roma or Dioscuri types reflected propaganda about the city of Rome: thus, on this argument, what we may call a general form of propaganda, analogous to the American eagle, is found on the earliest denarii. A second class of propaganda (Crawford's "private types")[18] features types that are not specifically

[13] Ibid., 156; earlier Greek legends reflected "a lack of interest of late 4th century Romans in the written word," with renewed interest when Latin legends begin to appear.

[14] Ibid., 166–67, 253–55.

[15] Ibid., 213, though he emphasizes as well the importance of visual propaganda. The idea of the army being the primary audience of coin types is not new to Harris; see A. Jones, "Numismatics and History," in *Essays in Roman Coinage Presented to H. Mattingly,* ed. R. Carson and C. Sutherland (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1956), 14–15. Though he agrees that the average soldier could read enough Latin to understand the inscription, he dismisses the idea of propaganda on coins.

[16] See Jones, "Numismatics," Crawford, "Public Opinion," and B. Levick, "Propaganda and the Imperial Coinage," *Antichthon* 16 (1982): 105–107, who suggests the types were marks of respect for the emperor, not chosen by the emperor for his own purposes. See also A. Wallace-Hadrill, "Image and Authority in the Coinage of Augustus," *JRS* 76 (1986): 66–87.

[17] Crawford, "Public Opinion," 57–58; Grant, *Anniversary,* 8, citing an earlier article of his; see also p. xv n. 3; Jones, 14; Belloni, "Propaganda," 150–51; A. Burnett, "The Iconography of Roman Coin Types in the Third Century B.C.," *NC* 146 (1986): 75; idem, *CRW,* 66–69; Sutherland, "Compliment," 87; idem, "Purpose," 80; Ehrhardt, 44; Levick, 106–7.

[18] Crawford, *RRC* p. 712ff.

related to Rome, but which show familial or personal propaganda. This kind is first introduced in the second half of the second century and culminates in the use of the emperor's portrait. The most obvious examples of "private" types are those that make a pun on the moneyer's name (e.g., Junius Silanus, with an obverse of a mask of Silenus, *RRC* 337/1).

The confusion concerning when coin types actually began to serve as vehicles of propaganda may stem from the lack of distinction between generalized and familial, or factional, propaganda. Most modern scholars believe that coin types were propagandizing by the first century;[19] some have further refined the date by making the Civil War the impetus to begin propagandizing.[20] But some scholars have detected this trend earlier; Mattingly believed propagandizing occurred as soon as the types broke away from the standardized Roma, Dioscuri, and chariot types.[21] The most radical viewpoint speculates that the earliest coins minted by Rome are propagandistic.[22]

Tackling both kinds of propaganda separately may perhaps allow some sense to be made of the problem. The earliest Roman issues to bear types are the bronze bars called *aes signatum*. These are cast with varying types,

[19] E.g., *RRC* 480/5, pairing a portrait of Caesar and the head of Venus Victrix (44 B.C.); or 485/1, Caesar and Venus? with caduceus and scepter (43 B.C.), cited by P. Hill, "Coin-symbolism and Propaganda during the Wars of Vengeance," *NAC* 4 (1975): 158.

[20] As Morawiecki, 104; P. Hill, 157; and A. Sturminger, *3,000 Jahre politiche Propaganda* (Munich: Verlag Herold, 1960), 104–5. All three agree that propaganda had appeared in coin types earlier, but only sporadically. Hannestad accepts the propaganda value of Late Republican/Imperial coins, though not any earlier coins (in *Roman Art and Imperial Policy*, Jutland Archaeological Society Publ. 19 [Aarhus: Aarhus University Press, 1986], 11–12; see 20–21), as does R. Scheiper, *Bildpropaganda der römischen Kaiserzeit* (Bonn: R. Habelt Gmbh., 1982), Habelts Dissertationsdrucke Reihe Klass. Arch. no. 15, 35, 66.

Part of the problem of defining propaganda in coin types is that we do not know for certain who picked the types (see more on the Hercules didrachm, chapter 4). Most numismatists would agree with Burnett (Coinage, 20–22) that the panel of moneyers, the *tresviri a.a.a.f.f.* as they called themselves, was probably instituted at the introduction of the denarius, and these men would pick their own coin types. Yet the Senate was responsible for picking the first denarius types, Burnett argues, since the same types are produced at mints in Rome, Sicily, Sardinia, Lucera in Spain, and at other unknown mint sites.

[21] H. Mattingly, "Some New Studies of the Roman Republican Coinage," *ProcBritAc* 39 (1953): 282. He feels the propaganda was more disguised in the first half of the first century because the moneyers tended to be clients of the great families, rather than members of those houses. See also Wallace-Hadrill, "Image and Authority," 74, citing T. Veturius (*RRC* 234), whose coin repeats an ancient type; and Hannestad, *Imperial Policy*, 21.

[22] A. Alföldi, "The Main Aspects of Political Propaganda on the Coinage of the Roman Republic," in *Essays in Roman Coinage Presented to H. Mattingly*, ed. R. Carson and C. Sutherland (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1956), 63; see also Belloni, "Propaganda," 131, and Zehnacker 1:476; earlier in his book (254–55) he cited the Hercules didrachm and the *aes signatum* with the Pyrrhic war types as the earliest (third century) examples.

including a shield and sword, or a wheat ear and tripod; only one carries an inscription, ROMANOM (e.g., *RRC* 2, 3). The *aes signatum* bearing the types elephant/pig can be dated by events in Rome's history. Elephants were first seen in Rome after their capture at the battle of Beneventum (ca. 275 B.C.). But the pairing of the elephant with a pig suggests that the types refer to an episode during the battle of Asculum (ca. 279 B.C.), when Pyrrhus' war elephants were routed by grunting hogs. The bars have been dated by Thomsen to the 270s.[23]

The types on two other *asses* have also been seen to be reflecting contemporary events. Those *asses* carrying an eagle perched on a thunderbolt on one face and Pegasus on the other (these are the bars inscribed ROMANOM) commemorate the fourth treaty between Rome and Carthage, ratified in 279.[24] Likewise, the *asses* featuring chickens and stars/prows and dolphins are thought to refer to a contemporary naval victory, either Ecnomus (256) or Aegates Insulae (241).[25]

Thus, the use of generalized propaganda on Roman coins from the third century onward is clear. Most scholars date the practice of including familial propaganda in the coin types to some point during the second century.[26]

[23] A. Burnett, "The Coinages of Rome and Magna Graecia," *SNR* 56 (1977): 113; *RRC* p. 718; Thomsen, *ERC* 1:157, 3:121, 145–47, 218; Zehnacker 1:15–16, 254–55. T. Comparette, *Aes Signatum* (Chicago: Obol International, 1978; reprint of "Aes Signatum," *AJNum* 1918: 1ff.), 30–31, 33, 35, suggests instead that the hog refers to the Italian allies of Pyrrhus, and the numismatist therefore removes the *asses* from the mint controlled by Rome.

Crawford takes issue with these interpretations, saying that the types "reflect the complete lack of interest of whoever was responsible for choosing the types, presumably the Censors. Many of the types have no conceivable significance and were presumably only selected because it was an accepted convention that a coin or coin-like object such as a piece of *aes signatum* had to have something on it" (*RRC* p. 713). Yet, on p. 714, Crawford calls the Hercules didrachm "distinctively Roman . . . highly suitable for a coinage struck from the spoils of war and perhaps reflecting the Roman ideology of military prowess." Cf. Thomsen, *ERC* 3:121.

[24] Comparette, 37–38; this interpretation is supported by Thomsen, *ERC* 3:218.

[25] Thomsen, *ERC* 3:143–45. Crawford, *RRC* p. 718 and n. 2, believes that Thomsen has misunderstood the types, although Crawford admits the type alludes to the Dioscuri. Comparette, 47–54, also removes this *aes* from the Roman mint, and dates it to the First Punic War, after the Romans had a navy.

[26] *BMCRR* 1:lxxxvii, with the coins of C. Renius; see also Cesano, "Fasti," 109; Zehnacker 1:460; J. Milne, "The Problem of the Early Roman Coinage," *JRS* 36 (1946): 99; Torelli, *Typology*, 103; and Kent, *Roman Coins*, 14, the coins of Sex. Pompeius Fostlus (discussed in chapter 4). Although I disagree with Kent's attribution of Pompeius' coins to familial propaganda, the contemporary coins of C. Minucius Augurinus certainly bear a reverse type commemorating his family.

While most scholars agree that the third-century Hercules didrachm types reflect familial propaganda on the part of the Ogulnii and Fabii families, it has scarcely been noticed that such familial advertisement disappears from the coinage for about fifty years. The special problems surrounding the didrachm types are discussed in chapter 4.

The interpretation of subsequent coin types that feature figures from Rome's immediate or far distant past begins, and often ends, with the pronouncement that the coin types reflect the moneyer's desire to claim descent from these figures. Although the moneyer's boasts of descent from heroes of the recent historical past can be proven, the types that supposedly claim descent from early heroes or kings have not been studied in light of the literary evidence for such claims. Indeed, it is widely believed, as Mattingly stated, that coin types with scenes from Rome's early history are not "far from family history, for, even where we cannot now trace it, family allusion is always to be suspected in reference to the past."[27]

Yet the argument is sometimes felt to be less stable than it appears. For example, it has been generally supposed that when L. Titurius Sabinus minted coins with Titus Tatius on the obverse, the type alluded to his family's Sabine descent, possibly even to descent from the king.[28] It has recently been recognized, however, that Titurius' cognomen alone "provides no real evidence for attributing a Sabine *origo* to the moneyer."[29] Further, a certain Q. Titius, striking in the same period as Titurius, had a much more orthographically attractive cognomen than Titurius to indicate descent from Tatius, yet he did not use the king's portrait on any of his coins.[30]

Clearly the arguments based on coin types can be circular: the coin types are said to refer to the origins of a moneyer's family, and for this reason the tendency is to assume that whenever a type picturing a figure from Rome's early history appears, this is further evidence that moneyers were claiming descent from these figures. In order to break the circle, the problem should be approached from a different perspective. Claims of descent can be traced in the literary sources; by discovering when the claim was made, we can judge whether or not these genealogies had any effect on the types minted by members of the family making such claims.

Because of the nature of the surviving ancient sources, genealogical pretensions are found widely scattered in the works of Cato, Livy, Dionysius

[27] H. Mattingly, *Roman Coins*, 3d ed. (Chicago: Quadrangle Books, 1962), 72; see also p. 73 where he writes, "The motive for such allusions [to the legends of early Rome] is partly family pride, partly antiquarian interest, intensified by the desire to see the present parallel to the past event." Alföldi, "Main Aspects," 66, says this was done " . . . with the purpose of presenting their offspring in the brilliant light of the great achievements of their forerunners." Zanker (*Images*, 13) recently has theorized that the patron who paid for the so-called Ahenobarbus base was claiming ancestry from Poseidon.

[28] Syd., p. 149 n. 905; Zehnacker 1:496, 511; *BMCRR* 1:297 n. 1, 417 n. 2; Cesano, "Fasti," 129. For a discussion of Titurius' coins, see chapter 7.

[29] *RRC* p. 355.

[30] J.-P. Morel, "Thèmes sabins et thèmes numaïques dans le monnayage de la république romaine," *MEFRA* 74.1 (1962): 32 n. 1.

of Halicarnassus, Plutarch, Suetonius, and Vergil. But such claims of descent do not suddenly arise in the last decades of the Republic. Some may even be traced to the third century B.C.; it may be that such genealogical claims are made known to the general public when the families became influential in Roman politics and could more easily manipulate "historical" records.

The claim of descent on the part of the Caecilii from Caeculus (Vulcan's son) may date to the third century, as the first Caecilius was elected consul in 284.[31] Numerous Caecilii Metellii mint, and only one (M. Metellus Q.f., *RRC* 263/2) features Vulcan on his coins.[32] The coin in question is a rare denomination, the dodrans, and it is because of the happy coincidence that Vulcan was normally portrayed on this denomination that he appears on Caecilius Metellus' coinage. But it is also true that Metellus certainly could have decided to mint this rare denomination in order to include Vulcan in his types.

The Geganii are another family who probably had an early claim of descent from a legendary figure. This family claimed two consuls in the fifth century, but soon produced no more officeholders; such an obscure family would have to have had an ancient claim of descent in order to be included in our first-century sources. They were one of the first to claim a Trojan ancestor, a companion of Aeneas called Gyas.[33] No Geganii minted.

The Trojan descent of the Nautii must also have been current in the third century because there are no known Nautii in the Senate after a consul of 287.[34] Their ancestor was named Nautes; no Nautii minted.

The historian L. Calpurnius Piso was responsible for transmitting the fabulous pedigrees of the Calpurnii, Pinarii, Pomponii, and Aemilii from Numa's sons Calpus, Pinus, Pompo, and Mamercus, or Aemylos.[35] That the Calpurnian claim of descent was current in the third quarter of the second century is established by the four consuls that the family produced

[31] Fest. p. 44M; Festus records a second tradition that Caeculus was one of Aeneas' companions. It should be noted that the third-century date for the Caecilian claim of descent was suggested by T. Wiseman, "Legendary Genealogies in Late-Republican Rome," *GaR*, n.s. 2, 21 (1974): 155; the family remained prominent into the Imperial period.

[32] The Caecilii who mint in the Republic are: C. Caecilius Metellus (*RRC* 269), Q. Caecilius Metellus (*RRC* 256), M. Caecilius Metellus Q.f. (*RRC* 263), M. Caecilius Metellus Q.f. (*RRC* 369), Q. Caecilius Metellus Pius (*RRC* 374), and Q. Caecilius Metellus Pius Scipio (*RRC* 459).

[33] Serv. *ad Aen.* 5.117.

[34] Wiseman, 154. The Nautii are mentioned in Varro's lost work, Fest. p. 166M; Serv. *ad Aen.* 2.166, 3.407, and 5.704, and Dion. Hal. *Ant. Rom.* 6.69.1.

[35] G. Forsythe, "The Historian L. Calpurnius Piso Frugi," Ph.D. diss., University of Pennsylvania, 1984, 234; see Plut. *Num.* 21 and Fest. p. 47M.

between 148 and 133. Naturally, Piso would have had a personal interest in recording the royal origin of the Calpurnian line. The Calpurnii, noted for the large issues they produced during the Social War and in the 60s, did feature Numa on one issue. This issue (as well as the problematic Augustan coinage) is discussed in detail in chapter 8.[36]

The Pinarii, who could boast of several early magistrates,[37] seem to have fallen into obscurity in the second century, only to become prominent once more in the first.[38] It is possible, then, that the Pinarian pretension to lofty antecedents may date earlier than that date given it in the list offered by Calpurnius Piso.[39] The two Pinarii who minted alone do so before types varied. A third minted for Antony and Octavian, and while his types are interesting, none feature Numa or, indeed, any Sabine theme.[40]

The Pomponii may also have claimed descent from Pompo before the mid-second century, as the family obtained consulships and priesthoods between the First and Second Punic Wars.[41] The Pomponii followed the pattern set by the Calpurnii; that is, one moneyer of the four Pomponii who minted featured Numa, and his coins are discussed in chapter 8.[42]

Several versions of the origin of the Aemilii are given. Although usually their sire was called Mamercus, who was also known as Aemylos, opinion was divided as to whether Mamercus was the son of Numa, Pythagoras, or Ascanius. A later source proposed a more fabulous sire in Jupiter.[43] What is certain is that the Aemilii used the name Mamercus as a praenomen or

[36] One Calpurnius minted too early for changing types; see also P. Calpurnius (*RRC* 247), L. Calpurnius Piso L.f. Frugi (*RRC* 340), C. Calpurnius Piso L.f. Frugi (*RRC* 408), M. Calpurnius Piso M.f. Frugi (*RRC* 418). Cn. Calpurnius Piso Frugi is represented only by one dupondius (*RRC* 547); the coins of Cn. Calpurnius Piso (*RRC* 446/1) and Cn. Piso Cn.f. (*RIC*[2] Augustus nos. 390-96) are discussed in chapter 8.

[37] P. Pinarius Mamertinus Rufus, cos. 489 (Broughton, *MRR* 1:18), L. Pinarius Mamertinus Rufus, cos. 472 (Broughton, *MRR* 1:29), P. Pinarius, cens. 430 (Broughton, *MRR* 1:64), and L. Pinarius Natta, mag. eq. 363 (Broughton, *MRR* 1:117).

[38] Because of their ancient claim to the administration of the rites of the Ara Maxima, the Pinarii also claimed descent from one of the early settlers of Evander's town (see Fest. p. 237M; Livy 1.7.12–13; Dion. Hal. *Ant. Rom.* 1.40.4; Serv. *ad Aen.* 8.270). Forsythe, 236–37, suggests that Piso, if he did not invent the Pinarian descent from Numa, at least passed on a contemporary claim.

[39] Cf. Plut. *Num.* 21.

[40] Pinarius Natta (*RRC* 200), Pinarius Natta (*RRC* 208), and L. Pinarius Scarpus (*RRC* 546), who mints for Antony and Octavian.

[41] Forsythe, 235, suggesting that their supposed descent may have influenced their acquisition of the priesthoods.

[42] L. Pomponius (*RRC* 282/4), Q. Pomponius Rufus (*RRC* 398), and Q. Pomponius Musa (*RRC* 410) mint non-Sabine themes; L. Pomponius Molo (*RRC* 334/1) is discussed in chap. 8.

[43] Silius Italicus *Pun.* 8.29–96.

a cognomen from about 500 to 350, and again after 150. This revival of the name shows that the claim of royal descent was "well known and was current" at the time Piso was writing.[44] Four Aemilii mint alone, all within the last 125 years of the Republic.[45] Yet instead of featuring any mythical ancestor on their coins, they generally minted reverses glorifying generals from their line.

Information concerning the origins of the Cloelii and the Mamilii dates to the second century. The Cloelii are one of the Alban families Titus Tatius brought to Rome, though they claimed that they were originally descended from the Trojan Clonius.[46] No Cloelii minted.

The Mamilii, Cato informs us, were descended from Telegonus, Ulysses' son.[47] The Mamilii were unusual in their insistence on depicting the celebrated wanderer on their coins. Only two Mamilii minted, but both included Ulysses, identified by his cap and walking stick, in their types.[48] Indeed, L. Mamilius was the first Roman to place a legendary ancestor on a coin, minting *asses* between 189 and 180 with the normal Janus/prow types and Ulysses above the prow. C. Mamilius Limetanus continued the tradition, minting denarii ca. 82 with Ulysses on the reverses.

The Marcian claim of descent from Ancus Marcius can be traced to the second century, thanks to the mention Dionysius makes of his source, Cn. Gellius.[49] Seven Marcii minting alone are represented among the Roman moneyers.[50] Two in the late Republic mint types depicting Numa and or Ancus Marcius; these will be discussed in chapter 8. The remaining four mint at a time when it is fashionable to employ varying types and two of these Marcii (both Marcii Philippi) portray historical ancestors.[51]

[44] Forsythe, 235 and n. 485; his argument is based on the restoration of the Fasti for the consul of 77: MAM(ilius) [Ae]MILIV[s Mam.f. Lepi]D(us) LIVIA[nus], a man adopted by an Aemilius, thus the Mamercus is confidently restored. If the man was consul in 77, he was born ca. 120 and his adoptive father ca. 150; see also Wiseman, 153. Festus p. 23M and Plut. *Aem. Paul.* 1 mention the descent of the Aemilii; the family was included in Atticus' monograph; see Nepos *Att.* 18.

[45] Mn. Aemilius Lepidus (*RRC* 291), L. Aemilius Lepidus Paullus (*RRC* 415), L. Aemilius Buca (*RRC* 480), M. Aemilius Lepidus (?) (Syd., 1368).

[46] Livy 1.30.2; Dion. Hal. *Ant. Rom.* 3.29.7; Fest. p. 55M, and Serv. *ad Aen.* 5.117.

[47] Fest. p. 130M; see Forsythe, 271–72 and n. 578; Wiseman, 155.

[48] L. Mamilius is *RRC* 149; C. Mamilius Limetanus is *RRC* 362.

[49] Dion. Hal. *Ant. Rom.* 2.76.5, 3.35.3; Suet. *Caes.* 6; Plut. *Num.* 21; it is possible that Varro included the family in his monograph.

[50] M. Marcius Mn.f. (*RRC* 245), Q. Marcius (*RRC* 283), L. Marcius Censorinus (*RRC* 363); the Marcii Philippi are L. Marcius Philippus (*RRC* 293) and Q. [Marcius] Philippus (*RRC* 259); L. Marcius Philippus (*RRC* 425) and C. Marcius Censorinus (*RRC* 346) are discussed in chapter 8.

[51] Q. Marcius Philippus (*RRC* 259), L. Marcius Philippus (*RRC* 293).

The first mention of the familiar story of Venus as the divine ancestor of the Julii Caesares is harder to date, but it was certainly current by ca. 125, when a member of the gens featured the goddess on his denarii. The claim was repeated not long afterwards by L. Julius L.f. Caesar and finally by C. Julius Caesar himself.[52]

Although Vergil wrote that the Trojan Mnestheus gave rise to the Memmii, one branch of this gens was anxious to trace its line directly to Venus, instead of to Mnestheus as an intermediary.[53] L. Memmius (*RRC* 304) and C. Memmius C.f. (*RRC* 427) do no more than picture various gods and goddesses on their obverses and reverses. However, the Memmii of the Galeria tribe essentially insist on their descent from Venus, portraying her, with Cupid, in a biga on their reverses. One, L. Memmius, even placed Venus and Cupid on the prows on the reverses of his *as,* semis, and quadrans.[54]

By the late Republic, a predilection for tracing one's descent from the gods, the Trojans who accompanied Aeneas, or the early Roman kings had become very popular. T. Pomponius Atticus wrote a monograph on the origins of the Junii, Claudii Marcelli, Cornelii Scipiones, Fabii Maximi, and the Aemilii Paulli (so Nepos *Att.* 18 informs us; Atticus' own monograph has not survived). Varro met the continuing demand to advertise particular families' Trojan ancestry in a work now lost; two families who we know were included are the Nautii and the Julii.[55] Varro's and Atticus' contemporaries M. Valerius Messala and C. Julius Hyginus wrote in a similar vein, but we know nothing concerning their works on Roman ancestry.[56]

[52] Suet. *Caes.* 6, Varro's monograph; six Julii struck independent coinages (a seventh, L. Julius[?] Salinator, struck in conjunction with C. Cassius): these include three L. Julii (*RRC* 224, 323, and 352), who may be a separate branch of the Julii, Sex. Julius Caesar (*RRC* 258), L. Julius L.f. Caesar (*RRC* 320), and C. Julius Caesar, the dictator. The coins of the dictator (*RRC* 452, 458, 468, 482) are too well known to need further comment; the Aeneas denarius is discussed in chapter 3.

[53] Memmian descent from the Trojan Mnestheus, hence Venus: Verg. *Aen.* 5.117; Serv. *ad Aen.* 5.117; Lucr. *De rer. nat.* 1.1.26.

[54] L. Memmius (*RRC* 304), C. Memmius C.f. (*RRC* 427), L. Memmius (Galeria) (*RRC* 313), L. and C. Memies L.f. (Galeria) (*RRC* 349).

[55] Serv. *ad Aen.* 2.166, cf. 3.407, 5.704.

[56] The late Augustan/early Tiberian work of M. Valerius Messalla Corvinus *(De fam.)* attempted to straighten out dangerously mixed lineages. See R.E.A. Palmer, *The Archaic Community of the Romans* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1970), 290–91, and Wiseman, passim, for discussions on the genealogical pretensions of late Republican families.

This was a long-lived tradition; Ariosto in *Orlando Furioso* traced the genealogy of the Este family back to Priam and Hector, though competing works claimed ancestors in the Trojan Antenore or the Republican Acci. The Este family seems to have been Bavarian in origin.

The pretenses of ten more families are hard to date, but all are included in the late Republican monographs or can be demonstrated to have occurred in Republican writings (of which Festus is the best source). The exceptions are the Cluentii, whose claim may date to the Augustan period, and the Metillii, who may have been added by Dionysius to the list of Alban families brought to Rome.

As the appetite for claiming Trojano-Alban descent grew in the late Republic and early Empire, the list of families claiming such descent comes to include the Curiatii (who claim they are descendants of the duelers in Livy 1.24), the Geganii, the Quinctii or Quinctilii, and the Servilii, all of whom are included in Livy's and Dionysius' list of Alban families brought to Rome by Titus Tatius.[57] The Cluentii claimed Cloanthus as their Trojan ancestor; the Cornelii Scipiones and the Claudii Marcelli were included in Atticus' monograph; the Junii not only proudly featured one of the first consuls among their ancestors, but also claimed Trojan descent for him. The Trojan companion of Aeneas, Sergestus, supposedly gave rise to the Sergeii.[58]

Within this formidable list, the presence of moneyers in a gens and those moneyers' use of coin types both vary greatly. No Cluentii or Metillii mint, the Curiatii are only represented at a very early period, and the Claudii Marcelli only mint in conjunction with other moneyers. The Quinctii or Quinctilii produce only three moneyers between the two families, but one man, Sex. Quinctilius (*RRC* 152), mints too early for changing types and neither of the other two makes reference to his supposed Trojano-Alban descent.[59] The Servilii, on the other hand, are well represented. The family produced six moneyers after types begin to vary, but again, none shows any interest in Trojan or Alban themes. Like the Aemilii, they tend to feature historical ancestors.[60]

Several branches of the Cornelian gens mint,[61] but only one Cornelius

[57] Livy 1.30.2; Dion. Hal. *Ant. Rom.* 3.13.4 and 3.29.7; and also Columella 3.8.1 for the Curiatii. The Quinctii or Quinctilii are called early Romans by Ovid (*Fast.* 2.373–80).

[58] Cluentian descent is noted by Vergil (*Aen.* 5.122) and may be an Augustan fiction; the Junii were mentioned in Atticus' monograph (Nep. *Att.* 18) and Dion. Hal. *Ant. Rom.* 4.68.1; the Sergeii in Verg. *Aen.* 5.121; Serv. *ad Aen.* 5.117; Dion. Hal. *Ant. Rom.* 6.69.2 and Varro's monograph, as mentioned in Servius; the Cornelii Scipiones and Claudii Marcelli in Atticus' monograph (Nep. *Att.* 18).

[59] T. Quinctius Flamininus (*RRC* 267), Ti. Quinctius or Quinctilius (*RRC* 297) omit reference to Trojan ancestry.

[60] C. Serveilius (*RRC* 264), C. Serveilius (*RRC* 370), M. Serveilius C.f. (*RRC* 327), C. Serveilius C.f. (*RRC* 423), C. Serveilius M.f. (*RRC* 239), and P. Servilius Rullus (*RRC* 328).

[61] Cn. Cornelius Blasio Cn.f. (*RRC* 296).

Scipio.[62] The preferred type for the Cornelii Lentuli includes the Genius of Rome; Jupiter is also favored, but no Trojan or Alban themes appear.[63]

Marcus Brutus was the first Junius to place his ancestor on a coin. His types are familiar to any student of Roman history (see also chapter 9), and he naturally chose to emphasize his descent from the first consul rather than his Trojan ancestor.[64]

Only one Sergius minted, and he is apparently more interested in portraying a historical ancestor than a mythical one.[65]

The Fabii claimed descent through Hercules,[66] and although they were immediately involved with Hercules' cult in Rome and elsewhere, aside from the case of a quadrans minted by L. Fabius Labeo, no Fabius ever placed him on a coin. Labeo's coin can be explained in the same manner as Caecilius Metellus' (see above, p. 25), as it was the normal quadrans type.[67]

Three other families prided themselves in having come from Sabine stock—the Aurelii, the Claudii, and the Valerii.[68] Two Aurelii minted alone, and only one of those men falls into the period of varied types. However, it should be noted that he does not pick a Sabine theme for his denarii.[69] The Claudii are hardly better represented by their moneyers, and again, no Sabine themes are found on Claudian coins.[70] The Valerii produced more moneyers, who were four in number, but none mints with any Sabine type.[71]

[62] L. Cornelius Scipio Asiaticus (*RRC* 311).

[63] P. Cornelius Lentulus Marcelli f. (*RRC* 329), P. Cornelius Lentulus Spinther (*RRC* 397), Cn. Cornelius Lentulus Clodianus (*RRC* 345), Cn. Cornelius Lentulus Marcellinus (*RRC* 393 and 549), the dictator L. Cornelius Sulla (*RRC* 359), the dictator's son Faustus Sulla (*RRC* 426), and P. Cornelius Lentulus Marcellinus (*RRC* 439).

[64] Only two other Junii mint alone or after types varied: D. Junius Silanus (*RRC* 337) and M. Junius Silanus (*RRC* 542).

[65] M. Sergius Silus (*RRC* 286); M. Sergius Silanus (*RRC* 285) mints in conjunction with two other moneyers.

[66] Ovid *Fast.* 2.237, *Pont.* 3.3.100; Plut. *Fab. Max.* 1; Silius Italicus *Pun.* 2.3–6; the family was featured in Atticus' monograph (Nep. *Att.* 18).

[67] For the involvement of the Fabii in Hercules' cult, see chapter 4 and the Hercules didrachm. Five Fabii minted; additionally, an issue was struck under the auspices of L. Fabius L.f. Hispaniensis (*RRC* 366). All date to the period when changing types and familial references are common: see Q. Fabius Maximus (*RRC* 265), Q. Fabius Maximus (*RRC* 371), Fabius Labeo (*RRC* 273), N. Fabius Pictor (*RRC* 268), and C. Fabius C.f. Hadrianus (*RRC* 322).

[68] For Aurelian descent, see Fest. p. 23M. For Claudian, Suet. *Tib.* 1; Verg. *Aen.* 7.706–9. The Valerii are said by Dionysus of Halicarnassus (*Ant. Rom.* 2.46.3) to have come to Rome with Tatius.

[69] L. Aurelius Cotta (*RRC* 314).

[70] C. Claudius Pulcher (*RRC* 300), Ti. Claudius Ti.f. Ap.n. Nero (*RRC* 383).

[71] L. Valerius Flaccus (*RRC* 306), C. Valerius Flaccus (*RRC* 365), M. Valerius Messalla f. (*RRC* 435), L. Valerius Acisculus (*RRC* 474).

Conclusions

In the course of this discussion we have determined that coin types are indeed propagandistic. However, we have also noted that propaganda on coins is not limited to a particular kind, but rather that generalized propaganda and familial propaganda can and must be carefully distinguished. Generalized propaganda appears on the earliest kind of coin minted by the Roman state—the *aes signatum*—and it continues to be the only kind of propaganda found on coins until the moneyers feel free to place their family names on the coins around 200 B.C. Such tentative steps towards familial propaganda are followed by the introduction of reverse types that are intended to glorify the family rather than the state. As we noted in the categorization of the types, generalized propaganda found a steadily smaller place on the coinage as familial types grew in importance and variety.

Although we have evidence of only three families who claimed descent from legendary figures in the third century, we can watch the numbers swell through the second and first centuries. By the 40s, nineteen or twenty more families claimed as ancestors figures from Rome's early history.

The coins present a more conservative picture. A bronze coin featuring a legendary ancestor of the moneyer's family appears only in the second decade of the second century. The precious metal coinage waited an additional fifty-five years before the moneyer's ancestry could be pictured. However, as soon as varying types appeared on coins, a Minucius featured two of his ancestors on the reverses of his denarii.[72]

Legendary ancestors are slow to appear on precious metal coins, and the Venus type may have been the first to occur because the goddess was already featured in more conservative types, that is, on coins that did not display a family's ancestry. In the last quarter of the second century, she is used by both the Memmii of the tribe Galeria and the Julii Caesares to claim Trojan, or more properly, divine ancestry.

It is not until an entire generation has passed that a second coin type depicting the moneyer's mythical ancestor appears. It is only at the time of the Social War that legendary ancestors were more readily portrayed; a Pomponius, a Marcius, a Memmius, and a second Mamilius minted coins celebrating their mythical descent. A lapse of another generation occurred before the types reappeared, this time on coins of M. Brutus. The reintroduced theme was swiftly followed by moneyers of the Marcii, Calpurnii,

[72] The bronze coin of Mamilius, cited above, is *RRC* 149; the coin of L. Minucius Augurinus is *RRC* 242, ca. 135 B.C.

and Julii and by a second issue of M. Brutus, before breaking off after Actium, at which point the types were used to honor Augustus rather than the moneyer's family. Put in quantitative terms, of seventy-one moneyers who had the opportunity to boast of their legendary ancestry on coins from the mid-second century on, only 11, or 15 percent, took advantage of the opportunity to do so. Of these, the majority comes from four upstart families—the Julii Caesares, the Memmii of the Galeria tribe, the Mamilii, and the Marcii.[73]

We should take these findings as a sign that figures from the early history of Rome should be used very carefully as evidence that the families claimed descent from the figure depicted on the coin. Instead, however, it is preferable for the evidence of the coin types to be used in conjunction with the literary sources to prove such a claim of descent. Once that evidence has been gathered, it can be seen how tenuous is our supposition that coin types generally reflect an interest by the moneyer in promoting his family's ancestry. We must be careful not to confer genealogies on moneyers who used figures from the history of early Rome. Rather, we should examine the types in light of the political and social circumstances at the time of minting; more illumination may be shed on the types by suggesting a political interpretation of them in cases where a claim of familial descent cannot be traced.

[73] The Julii Caesares are a patrician family, though "newly arisen [in the first century B.C.] from long decay" (Syme, *Revolution,* 25, 68). The Marcii come from plebeian aristocracy, are in eclipse in the second century, and regain offices in the first (see Syme, *Revolution,* 85). None of the Memmii of the Galerian tribe nor any of the Mamilii rise higher than tribune of the plebs.

Although it was generally agreed by ancient historians that several families who were brought into the Senate by Romulus composed the *gentes maiores,* there was some confusion among ancient historians as to who the exact families were. Furthermore, the relationship between the *gentes maiores* and the patricians was unclear (see, e.g., Livy 1.8, 30 and Dion. Hal. *Ant. Rom.* 2.8, 9.1). The *gentes minores* (or "newer") would thus consist of Latin, Sabine, or Etruscan families brought into the Senate. But again they are not clearly differentiated from, or parallel to, the plebeian *gentes.* For a recent discussion on this knotty problem, see R. Mitchell, *Patricians and Plebeians* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1990), 16–26, 97–98.

TABLE 1. Percentages of Precious-Metal Type-Pairs (based on *RRC* and *RIC*[2])

Obverse		Reverse	
Type	%	Type	%
211–137 B.C. (250 type-pairs)			
Roma	100	Dioscuri	75
		Chariot	25
137–116/115 (100 type-pairs)			
Roma	94	Chariot	68
Deities[a]	4	Dioscuri	8
Dioscuri	2	Ancestral[b]	8
		Political/Judicial[c]	6
		Family Badges[d]	4
		Roma	2
		Legends of Rome[e]	2
		Military/Battle[f]	2
116/115–82 (150 type-pairs)			
Deities[a]	66	Chariot	34
Roma	31	Political/Judicial[c]	17
Miscellaneous	3	Deities[a]	15
		Military/Battle[f]	15
		Punning[g]	8
		Miscellaneous	10
82–54 (210 type-pairs)			
Deities[a]	57	Deities[a]	33
Unidentified Figures	33	Chariot	18
Roma	6	Military/Battle[f]	15
Legends of Rome[e]	2	Buildings	9
Political/Judicial[c]	1	Political/Judicial[c]	7
Greek Myth	1	Greek Myth	6
		Games	2
		Family Badges[d]	2
		Punning[g]	1
		Legends of Rome[e]	1
		Miscellaneous	7
54–44 (152 type-pairs)			
Deities	51	Deities	30
Unidentified Figures	20	Military/Battle[f]	25
Ancestral[b]	16	Political/Judicial/Priestly[c]	12
Roma	4	Chariot	8
Political/Judicial/Priestly[c]	3	Ancestral[b]	5
Legends of Rome[e], Punning[g], Miscellaneous	6	Legends of Rome[e]	4
		Roma	1
		Miscellaneous	14

TABLE 1—*Continued*

Obverses and Reverses combined	
Type	%
44–30 (142 type-pairs)	
Portraits of Living Persons	31
Caesar	2
Deities[a]	29
Military / Battle[f]	9
Political / Judicial / Priestly[c]	7
Unidentified Figures	5
Ancestral[b]	4
Buildings	3
Miscellaneous	9

Obverse		Reverse	
Type	%	Type	%
30–Death of Augustus (72 type-pairs)			
Augustus	64	Military / Battle[f]	25
Deities[a]	32	Buildings	13
Miscellaneous	2	Deities[a]	13
Epigraphic	1	Caesar / Family of Augustus	11
		Epigraphic	10
		Miscellaneous	8
		Priestly[c]	7
		Greek Myth	7
		Political[h]	5
		Legends of Rome[e]	1

Note: The types on the obverse and reverse are a type-pair. There is a special problem with attempting to quantify the reverses and obverses after 116/115 because of the ambiguity of the types, especially in the punning category. When citing L. Appuleius Saturninus' denarii, Saturn in a quadriga (*RRC* 317/2), is this to be counted as a pun on Saturninus or the quadriga type? I have tried to solve the problem by taking the type at face value, admittedly leaving much room for argument, but allowing some kind of measured results to be obtained.

a. including the performance of a ritual
b. historical ancestors, including portraits
c. symbols of offices, like the *sella curulis*; by 54, priestly items include the *simpulum*, etc.
d. primarily the elephant for the Metelli
e. the motives examined here, from Aeneas to L. Brutus
f. including trophies
g. on the family name, as Junius Silanus' Silenus
h. e.g., laurel branches flanking an oak wreath